



Ribeira Sacra Waterscape

Nomination of
**Ribeira Sacra
Waterscape**
for inscription on
the World Heritage List



XUNTA
DE GALICIA



GOBIERNO
DE ESPAÑA

MINISTERIO
DE CULTURA





State Party

Spain

State, Province and Region

Provinces of Lugo and Ourense, Autonomous Community of Galicia, Spain.

Name of nominated property

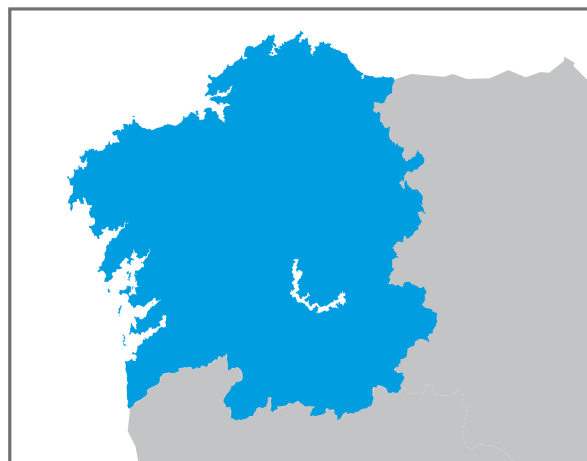
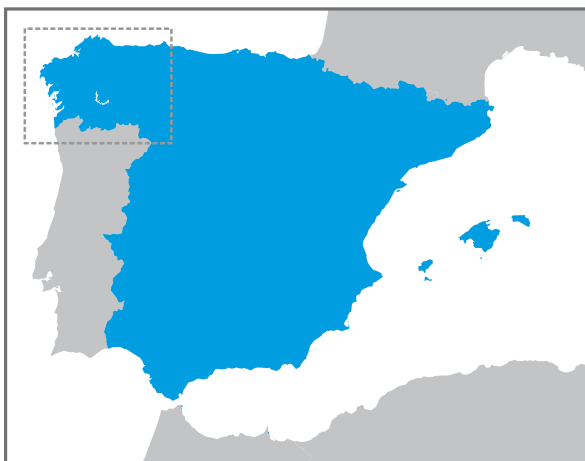
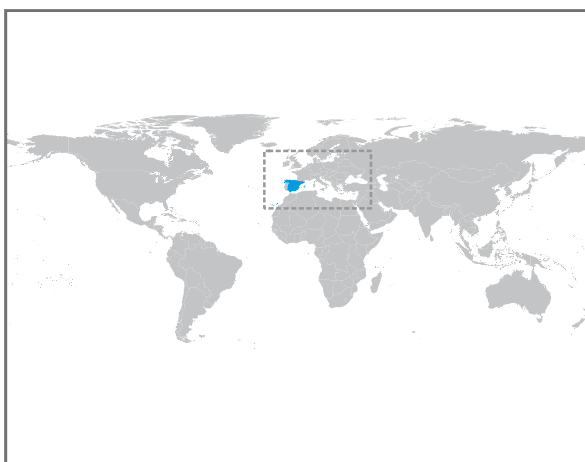
Ribeira Sacra Waterscape

Geographical coordinates indicating minutes and seconds

(WGS 84) N 42° 27' 14" / W 7° 43' 50"

(ETRS 89) UTM zone 29N: 604352 / 4700981

This is the point where the Sil and Miño rivers meet at the heart of the nominated property.



Textual description of the boundary of the nominated property

The boundary of the property runs along the upper contours of the entrenched valleys that lie at the confluence of the Sil and Miño rivers. The limits are delineated on the ground by what are known locally as *bocarribeiras*, which is where the slope changes abruptly from gradients steeper than 30% (*ribeiras*) to below 10% (*chairas*). The demarcation therefore includes these two river canyons between Santa María de Pesqueiras to the west and San Clodio de Ribas de Sil to the east, covering an area of 16,471 ha, with a perimeter of 273 km.

The buffer zone around the nominated property covers a surface of 31,979 hectares and is delimited by the 72 parishes that were established in the Middle Ages and that still survive today as identifiable territorial units.



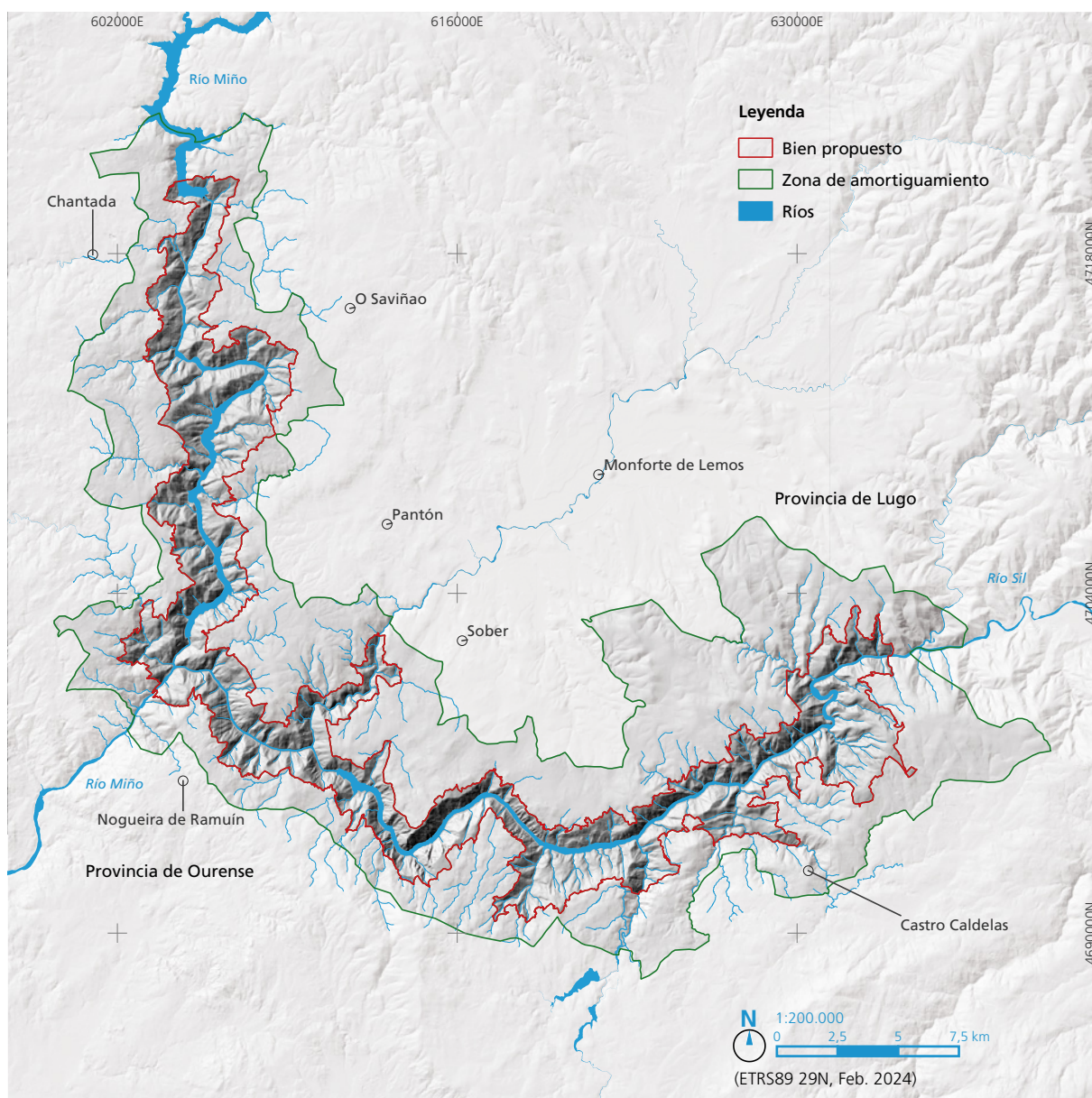
Object of personal adornment, dated to the Late Bronze / Early Iron Age, from the water storage facility at Santo Estevo de Ribas do Sil (Nogueira de Ramuín, Ourense).

© A. Trigo Arnal (National Museum of Archaeology)

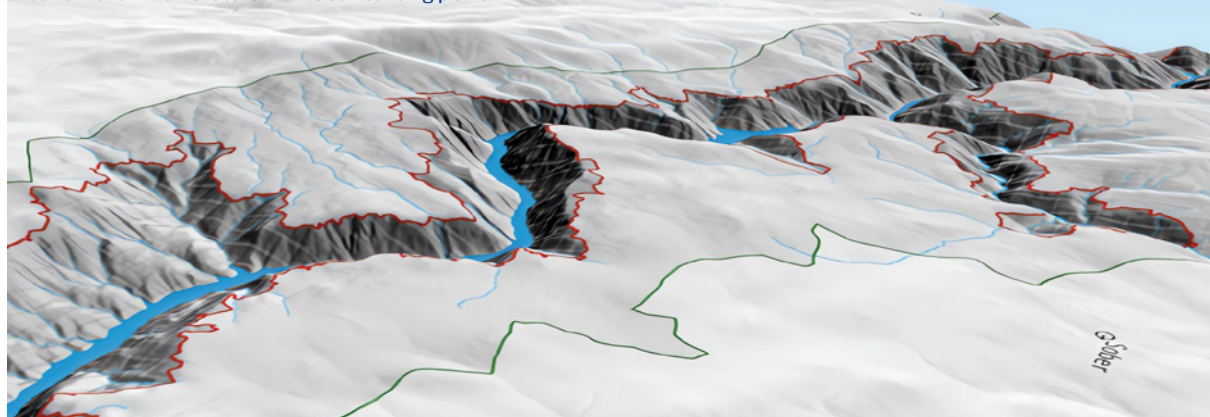
Meander on the river Sil from Vilouxé viewpoint. © R. Vilanova



Map of the nominated property



A digital terrain model of a section of the nominated property, showing the layout of the property boundary running along the edge of the river canyons and the scope of the buffer zone which is located in the surrounding plains.



Criteria under which property is nominated

Criterion (v)

Be an outstanding example of a traditional human settlement, land-use, or sea-use which is representative of a culture (or cultures), or human interaction with the environment especially when it has become vulnerable under the impact of irreversible change.

Cultural Landscape

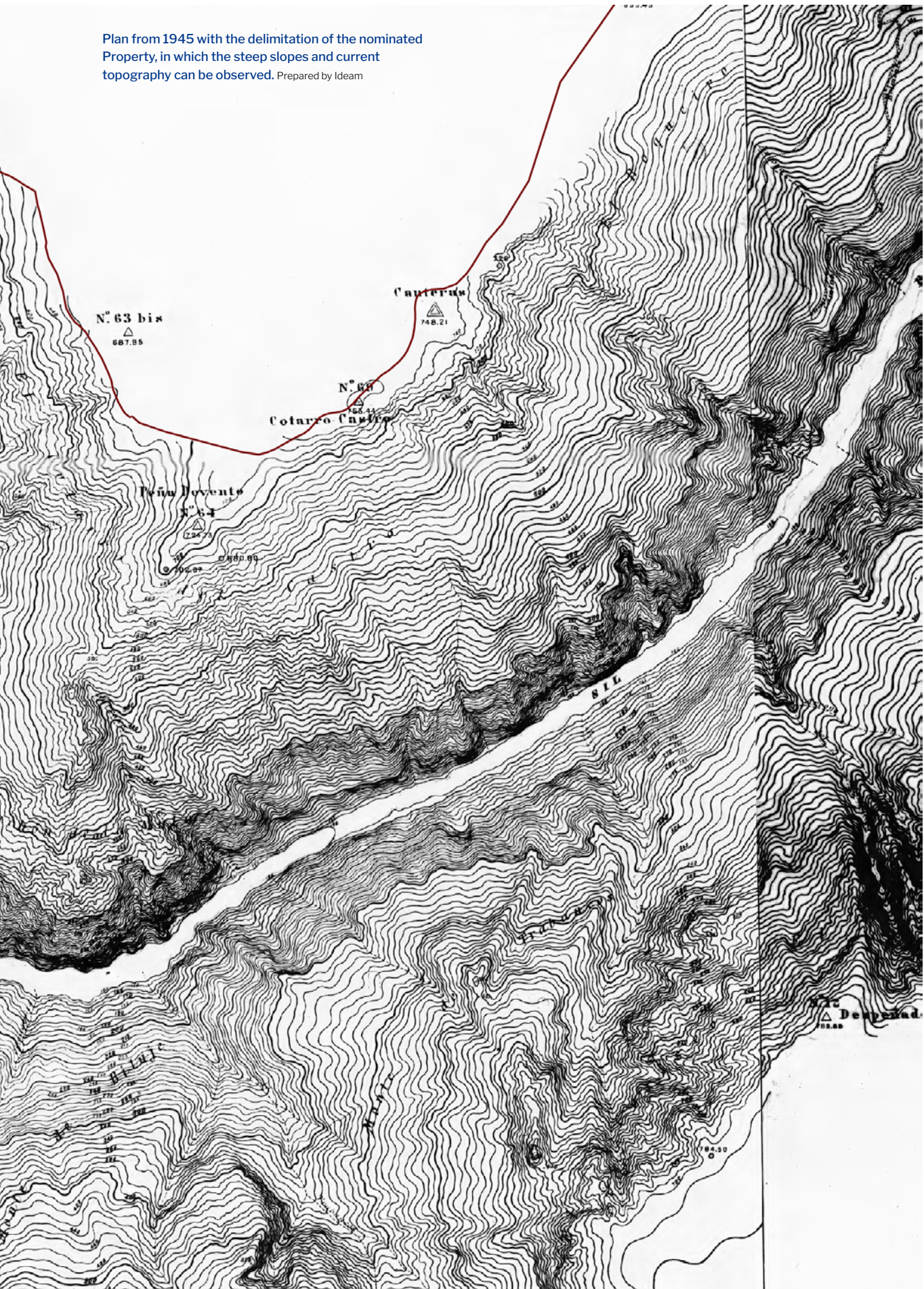
Yes

Sil canyon from A Columna viewpoint. © A. Rodicio





Plan from 1945 with the delimitation of the nominated Property, in which the steep slopes and current topography can be observed. Prepared by Ideam



Draft Statement of Outstanding Universal Value

a) Synthesis

The nominated property showcases an outstanding cultural waterscape, traditionally and popularly known as Ribeira Sacra, which is bounded by spectacular river canyons at the confluence of the Sil and Miño rivers (Galicia, Spain), located in the cool, damp climates of Northwest of the Iberian Peninsula.

It is an epic landscape, shaped by the culture and heritage of water and fed by the countless streams, brooks and rivers that define its identity, beauty, composition and unique settlement patterns. It traces the origins and evolution of a territory sculpted by water and is paradigmatic of a culture of water: one can clearly discern the marks of its construction over more than 1,500 years of continuous occupation, dating back to the ancient eremitic and monastic traditions that are deeply rooted in the region.

The culture of water in these places is revealed through an exceptional water heritage that includes archaeological sites, waterworks from all periods of history, including a significant water industry heritage, the unique drainage systems of the *socalcos* (terraces), and many other vernacular features in the form

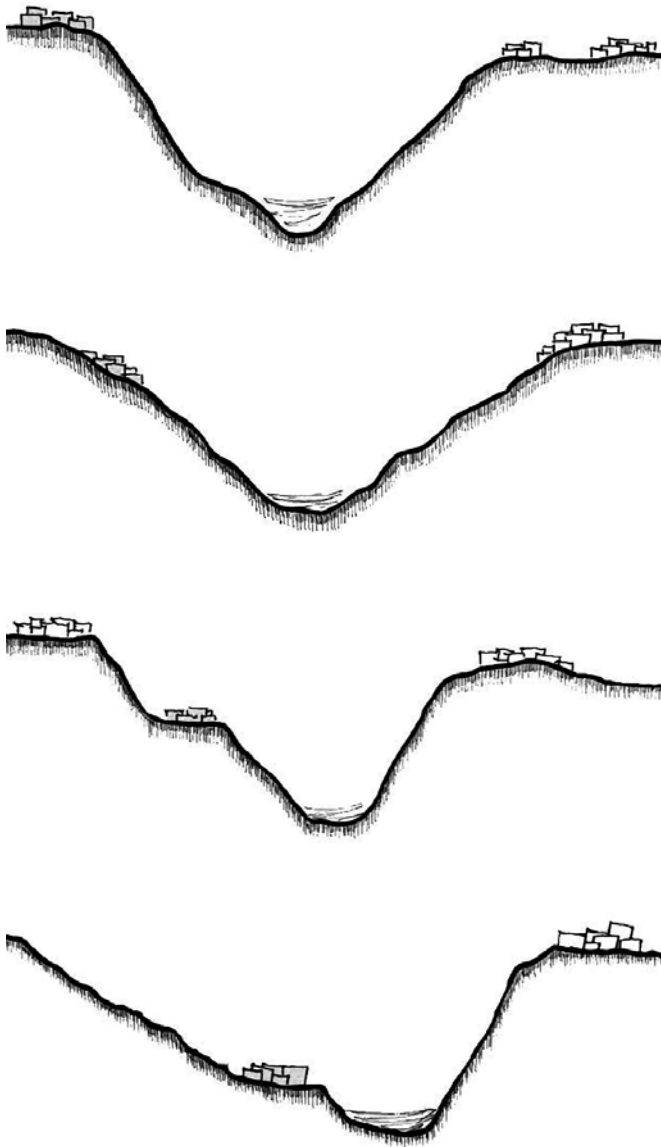
of consecrated fountains and mines, canals, weirs, crossings and bridges, river routes and other exceptional works associated with water.

The power of water is a central theme in the narrative of the cultural landscape. In the area of the nominated property there is a remarkable catalogue of water-use heritage features that bear constant witness to the energy self-sufficiency of each period. These range from traditional watermills from different centuries, which can still be seen throughout the property in exceptional numbers and density, to the mini-power stations or *factories of light* that emerged at the end of the 19th century, to the hydroelectric dams of the mid-20th century.

In short, Ribeira Sacra is a cultural landscape in which we can piece together the history of the wondrous relationship between water, humans and ingenuity, not only in ensuring their survival and well-being, but also in harnessing to the full all possible uses of water.

Aerial view in Trigoães. © R. Vilanova



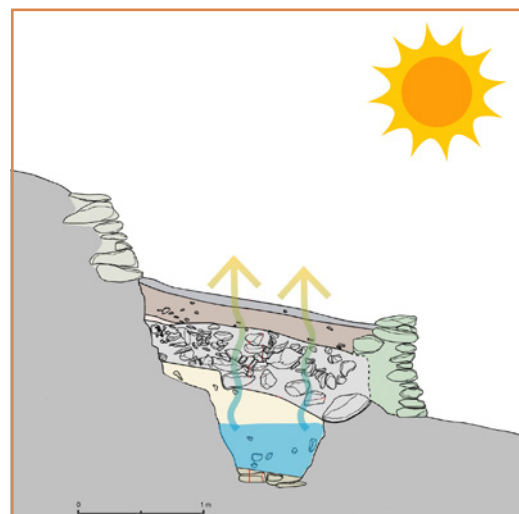
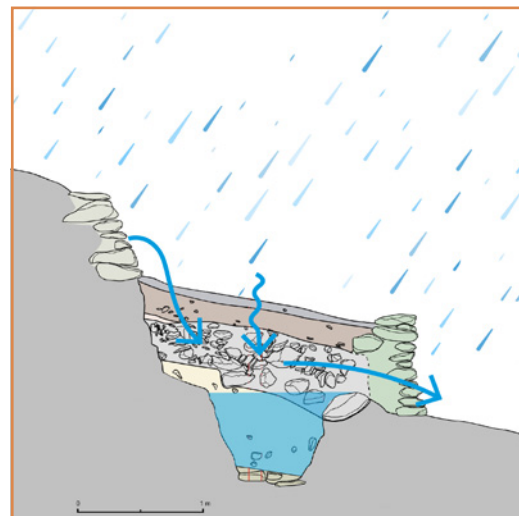


Examples of the four patterns or “place-types” of village location in relation to topography in Ribeira Sacra.

© Ramón López González (2018) , based on Augusto Pérez Alberti (2015)

The *socalcos* should be regarded as water-management systems that control heavy surface runoff and manage drainage, while also adapting to the local climate. The diagrams provide a simplified overview of their sections, construction elements and behaviour.

Redrawn by Crecente Asociados from a graph by Incipit CSIC



b) Justification for Criteria

Criterion (v)

Be an outstanding example of a traditional human settlement, land-use, or sea-use which is representative of a culture (or cultures), or human interaction with the environment especially when it has become vulnerable under the impact of irreversible change.

The nominated property bears exceptional testimony to a living cultural waterscape that has evolved organically over more than 1,500 years, and boasts an extraordinary repertoire of water works, knowledge and uses that have enabled communities to live there.

It is a complex landscape in which traditional forms of settlement persist alongside unique micro-plots that provide meaningful evidence of the ability of humans to organise and adapt to difficult environmental conditions. The property also features outstanding expressions of an agriculture practised on rugged terrain that has profoundly shaped the riverside landscape over the centuries in the form of *socalcos* (terraces) that carpet the slopes of the river canyons.

Ribeira Sacra contains a unique and remarkably complete example of hydraulic techniques that were developed for energy self-sufficiency over hundreds of years: countless traditional watermills from different periods and with different functions, evidence of the emergence of “white coal” (hydroelectricity) with power stations from the end of the 19th century, and more contemporary hydroelectric dams from the mid-20th century. It thus comprises a rich heritage catalogue of works that bear witness to the human adventure of harnessing the power of water, recognised as a clean and sustainable source of energy.

The nominated property attests to the profound interdependence between the cultural and natural heritage associated with the cultural waterscape, which can be clearly identified in intangible elements such as traditions, myths and legends, toponymy and the consecration of the many works associated with the management and use of water.

Mill on the river Xabrega. © E. de la Iglesia



c) Statement of Integrity

The boundaries of the component parts of the property have been strategically drawn in terms of integrity. As such, they cover an area of sufficient scale to allow for a full representation of the features and processes that lend significance to the nominated property, from the spectacular steep river valleys to the sharply sloping terraced hillsides rising from the riverbanks. Moreover, the history of this cultural waterscape and its compositional elements is clearly visible in the landscape, reflected in particular in an exceptional catalogue of waterworks and water-related heritage features, in the rows of crop terraces (*socalcos*), in the eremitic and monastic landmarks that reflect how the land was settled and that shaped the culture of water, and in the enduring presence of the ancestral micro-plots of land.

The cultural landscape contains more than enough elements to fully represent the values and attributes that convey the significance of the nominated property, both in terms of diversity and density: the many watercourses, the great profusion of water-related works, the rich historical heritage, and the diverse Riverside crops and uses.

The boundaries of the buffer zone have been established not only to actively contribute to the direct protection of the nominated property, but also to ensure the preservation of the viewsheds and the continuity and compositional integrity of the river landscape of Ribeira Sacra.

The nominated property is free from major threats and is of sufficient size to demonstrate how multiple systems – agricultural, hydraulic, ecological, territorial, social and spiritual – have interacted and adapted to different situations over time.

d) Statement of authenticity

All the components and their constituent elements are credible and genuine demonstrations of the different manifestations and configurations of the waterscapes they represent, and of the architecture, ensembles, waterworks, ethnological elements and, in general, the tangible and intangible heritage associated with them. Their authenticity is evident in the degree to which the qualities pertaining to the attributes conveying Outstanding Universal Value may be clearly identified and understood, particularly through their form, design, functionality, typology, materials, period and location. This is reflected in the specific features of its components, such as in the recognisable typologies of the waterworks and water-management systems of different periods, in the water-related layout of settlements and plots, or in the functionality and structure of the unique farming systems.

The authenticity of the different cultural waterscapes and heritage elements within the nominated property is confirmed by the cited documentary

sources and historical maps. The authenticity of the heritage elements is also attested by the large number of studies, inventories, catalogues and research undertaken on various aspects of the nominated property.

Furthermore, the nominated property is the embodiment of a vibrant, age-old cultural tradition in which genuine knowledge, practices and customs still persist. They are powerful reminders of the character and spirit of an area criss-crossed by endless ribbons of water, where local communities uphold their traditions, illustrating the unbroken sense of culture and identity associated with this place.

Ribeira Sacra has retained a high degree of authenticity as a whole, notably in its water-related heritage, in the farming systems, and in the perdurance of uses and materials, strengthened by the many conservation efforts that today maintain the active social role of this cultural landscape in perpetuating a sustainable economy.

e) Requirements for protection and management

The protection of the nominated property and its various components is fully safeguarded by the different regional, national and European laws and provisions that address the different realities and features that make up the cultural landscape.

The Ribeira Sacra Waterscape has a robust system of general protection that is primarily sustained by the designation of the entire area as Heritage of Cultural Interest (BIC) in the category of “cultural landscape”. This is the highest legal status that current regional and national legislation establishes for the recognition and protection of cultural manifestations and is the highest legal category for the protection and stewardship of cultural heritage assets at regional and national level in Spain.

The nominated property benefits from a Management System that includes a Management Plan and a governance system that are effective and adapted to the characteristics and needs of the cultural landscape. Both provide for the unified management of all the elements of the property, with a view to the future and sufficient capacity to preserve its Outstanding Universal Value over time and to address potential threats and vulnerabilities. The Management Plan is divided into seven programmes that include different actions of vital importance for the planning, development and protection of the property, the landscape and its cultural heritage, with a cross-cutting approach to achieving the proposed strategic objectives. For its part, the governance system ensures that all those involved in one way or another with the nominated property consider themselves to be participants and stakeholders in its management. To this end, a management structure has been set up for the nominated

property under the aegis of the Directorate General of Cultural Heritage of the Xunta de Galicia and co-ordinated by the Interdepartmental Commission of Ribeira Sacra. The Interdepartmental Commission is a participatory management body composed of representatives of public authorities and public bodies with competence in the area, in addition to a broad representation of the social and private entities involved in Ribeira Sacra.

The programmes included in the Management Plan are as follows:



CULTURAL LANDSCAPE AND TERRITORY PROGRAMME

This addresses the complete set of actions aimed at the improvement and maintenance of all the elements and processes, including the unique built elements and traditional river farming systems that shape the cultural landscape. It also deals with the improvement of the instruments of territorial planning and the management of the physical environment in accordance with the requirements and values of the cultural landscape, and in accordance with the Strategic Action Plan for the Ribeira Sacra, of the Regional Ministry of the Environment and Territory.



PROGRAMME FOR THE PRESERVATION OF WATER HERITAGE

This focuses on the restoration and conservation of the historical hydraulic and water heritage, both natural and cultural, which includes mills, water mills and fulling mills, as well as the extensive catalogue of heritage elements associated with water management.



PROGRAMME FOR THE PRESERVATION OF THE INTANGIBLE HERITAGE OF WATER

Aimed at reinforcing the identity and preservation of the elements that define a living waterscape, including traditions, knowledge, festivals, crafts and other aspects such as toponymy.



PROGRAMME FOR THE CONSERVATION OF NATURAL VALUES AND THE ENVIRONMENT

This focuses on issues associated with the conservation of biodiversity, especially in riverbeds and escarpments, and on issues associated with the environmental quality of the territory, including the environmental and vegetation cover restoration actions of the Landscape Action Plan of Ribeira Sacra.



SUSTAINABLE ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT PROGRAMME

This addresses the promotion of local productions and quality economies associated with the values and identity of the cultural landscape, as well as support for its image and marketing.



SUSTAINABLE TOURISM MANAGEMENT PROGRAMME

Focused on the attributes and values of the nominated property, it addresses the qualification and diversification of the responsible tourism offer and the public use of the space, and includes actions oriented towards sustainable land and water mobility, as well as the improvement and integration of visitor infrastructures to get to know the property, including viewpoints, museums and interpretation centres, both public and private.



AWARENESS, COMMUNICATION AND PARTICIPATION PROGRAMME

This focuses on the promotion of scientific research on the different values of the property, the development of educational projects centred on the cultural landscape, as well as the training and education of local agents. It also addresses the maintenance of the Interdepartmental Commission, awareness-raising campaigns aimed at the population, and communication and dissemination campaigns on the outstanding universal value of the nominated property.



Waterscape plaque
in a panel of Finca
Cortezada. © E. de la Iglesia

O Curral do Penso
viewpoint. © D. Estevez



Manual of good practices for visitors, included
in the Green Book for the sustainable
management of cultural heritage published
by the Ministry of Culture, 2023.



Finca Cortezada in 1925. Photograph by
Ruth Matilda Anderson for the Hispanic Society





Meander of O Cabo do Mundo. © R. Vilanova

Attributes

The main attributes that convey the Outstanding Universal Value of the nominated property are listed below, together with a list of their constituent elements.

The spectacular river canyons and valleys sculpted by water that are the exceptional physical features that inform and distinguish the cultural waterscape.

— Outstanding features: The canyons and steeply entrenched valleys of the Miño and Sil rivers that plunge down from the high surrounding plains; the abrupt relief; the deep and spectacular entrenched meanders; the extremely dense and hierarchical drainage system; the innumerable watercourses, springs, streams, brooks, waterfalls and fountains; the extensive and diverse mosaic of humanised vegetation; and the scenic beauty of the landscape.

85° maximum slope inclination

486 river courses

295 km of water courses

The exceptional, dense and diverse water heritage of the cultural landscape, which includes an extensive catalogue of energy harnessing solutions from the Middle Ages to the mid-20th century, exponents of the mediaeval technological revolution and the birth of hydroelectricity that form part of a representative compendium of the history of waterpower.

— Outstanding features: The hundreds of traditional watermills built since the 11th century, which endured and evolved until the mid-20th century and ensured energy self-sufficiency for the area, including complex water distribution and management systems; the construction of the first mini-power stations marking the emergence of hydroelectricity, following on from the traditional mills, between the end of the 19th century and the beginning of the 20th century; the excellent representation of the various types of hydroelectric dams that illustrate the exploits of hydroelectric engineering in the first half of the 20th century; and the immense repertoire of smallscale waterworks that are scattered throughout the cultural landscape.

668 traditional mills estimated

600,000 households supplied by the local hydroelectric production

41% of the Property in public water domain /police area

The enduring legacy of traditional farming systems on the steep slopes of the river canyons of the Ribeira Sacra, grounded in age-old techniques.

— Outstanding features: The terraces or *socalcos* as water-management systems that regulate drainage and the flow of water; the evolving design and inseparable association of the *socalcos* with the watercourses; the breathtaking agricultural terraces on exceptionally steep slopes as epic feats of human settlement.

2,494 hectares of *socalcos*

1,177 inhabitants

More than **500 m** of drops in some places

The eremitic and monastic heritage that shaped the distinctive and functional features of the cultural waterscape.

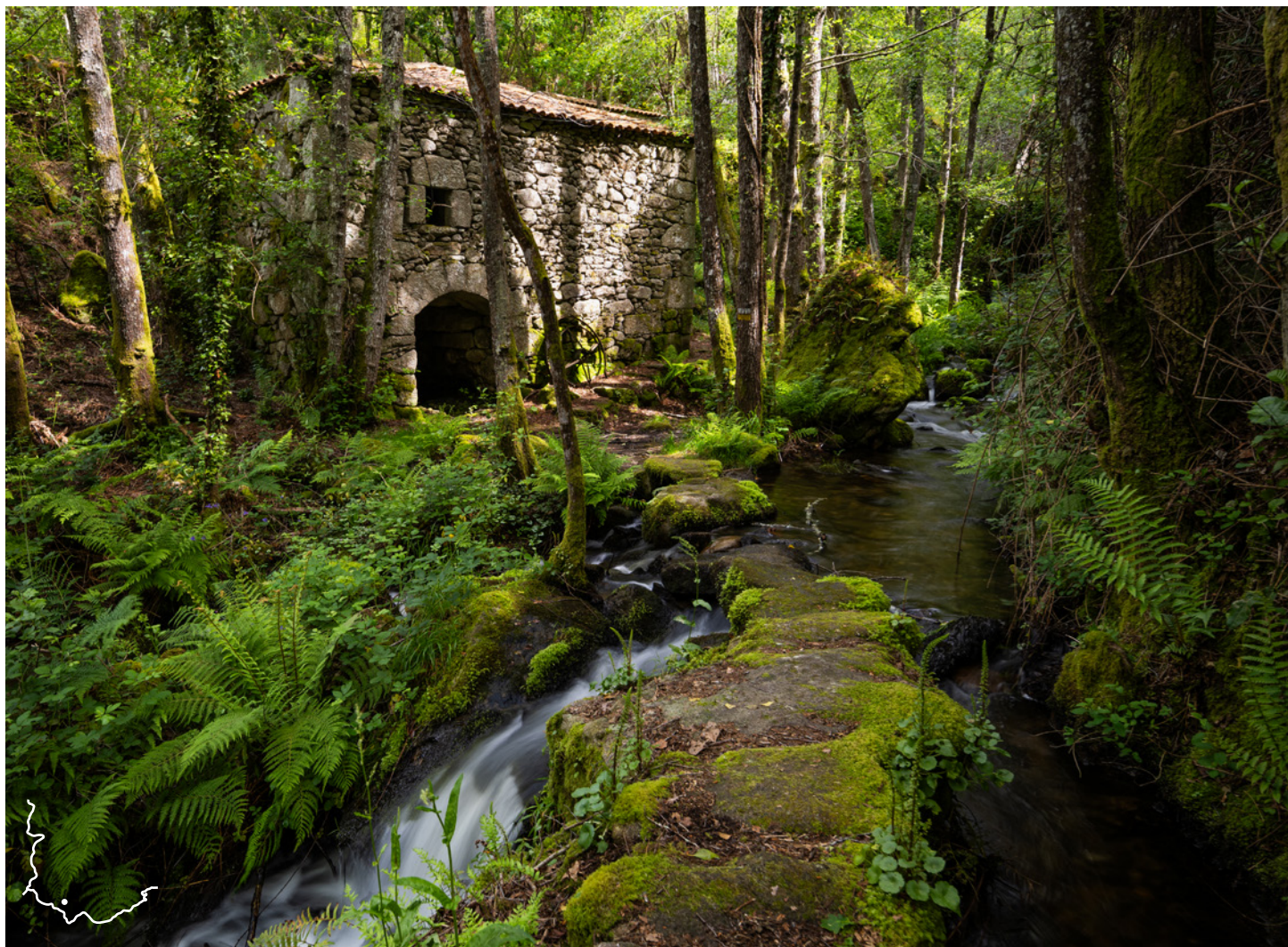
— Outstanding features: Traces left by the monasteries in the development of a water culture in the area, related to the land and watermill *aforamientos* (monastic property rights) throughout history, including the management of river resources, fishing and transport; the hermitages and the considerable number of churches and monasteries that shed light on an essential stage in the evolution of the cultural waterscape; and the distinctive orientations of the monastic landmarks in relation to the watercourses.

83 monasteries documented in the 22 town councils of the Heritage of Cultural Interest

12,000 km of dry stone walls.

89 viewpoints

Mill on the river Xabrega. © R. Vilanova



The unique land-use and land-tenure systems marked by the presence of water.

— Outstanding features: The continued existence of historical forms of occupying the river space and the settlement patterns; the organisation of the territory into parishes, identifying units delimited by watercourses dating back to the 6th century; and the thousands of tiny plots set out by ancestral practices of land and property management adapted to this rugged landscape.

96,125 plots

394 average plot surface, m²

72 parishes

The remarkable biocultural capital of a living cultural landscape and the intangible heritage associated with water culture.

— Outstanding features: The survival of traditional knowledge on how to build *socalcos*; the river harvest; the many festivals and traditions associated with rivers and streams; the consecration of fountains, mines and other elements of water heritage; the extraordinary toponymic heritage and the continued use of numerous unique hydronyms; the myths and legends featuring water as the central theme.

1,020 unique toponyms in the Ribeira Sacra area

167 population centres

1124 year of the first written reference to Rovoyra Sacrata

Monastery of Santo Estevo de Ribas de Sil,
photographed by Ruth Matilda Anderson in 1925.
Image provided by The Hispanic Society of America.



Name and contact information of official local institution

Institution:

Xunta de Galicia
Dirección Xeral de Patrimonio Cultural.

Address:

Edificio administrativo San Caetano, s/n
15781 Santiago de Compostela. Galicia. Spain

Tel:

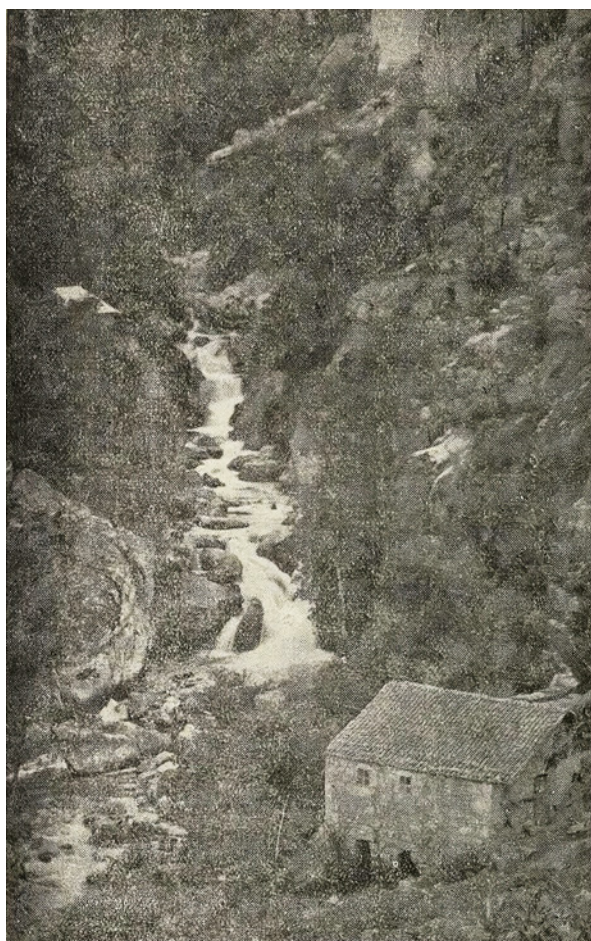
+34 981544809

E-mail:

patrimonio.cultura@xunta.gal

Website:

<https://ribeirasacrawaterscape.com>



Electra Popular and O Xordo mill, Asma
River, July 1929. © Revista Alicerces



Fontes Exhibition, during the homonymous meeting held in
Santo Estevo de Ribas de Sil in October 2024. © M. Crecente



Beginning of the score of the Muíñeira de
Chantada. The muíñeira, a traditional Galician
musical composition, has a 6/8 beat that was
created from the toothed gear of a mill.



MAPA
DE EL OBISPADO DE
ORENSE.

DELINEADO

Por D. Joseph Cornide,

vecino de la Ciudad de la Coruña

1763.



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